

Talk Is Cheap

"I have to give her credit. She looked pretty solid. Despite her age, Benz is still a dangerous fighter, and Harris did a great job of handling her. But that's not surprising. Danni was one of the best, so you'd expect her to still be pretty good."

"What the fuck does she mean, was?" Aly said.

She was clustered behind me with Emma and Tiz, watching Cheryl Cole's latest comments, given in a quick side interview with Rachel Nichols.

"Shhh," I said.

On the screen, Nichols more politely asked Cole the same question Aly had. Was she trying to say Danni was past her prime?

Cheryl didn't even stop to think it over.

"Well, she's past my prime, anyway. But I'm sure she can still give some of the older fighters a run for their money."

There was a brief second where even Nichols seemed to think, *What the fuck did you just say?* before Rachel decided she couldn't come up with a worthy follow-up and ended the interview.

I closed the browser window, then sat back and closed my eyes. Allowing myself a quiet moment to imagine what it might be like to strangle Cheryl Cole.

"What are we going to do about this?" Tiz asked.

"Nothing," I answered in my rational owner's voice.

"Nothing?" she stammered. "Are you serious? We can't let her get away with this!"

"Get away with what?" I asked. "Running her mouth? She's been doing that for years, and it's only gotten worse since she won the title."

"But she can't say shit like that about Danni!" Aly said.

"Are you new here?" I asked her. "This is what she does. She talks a bunch of shit to get her fans stirred up. She likes being the heel, and, let's face it, she's good at it."

"So, what are we supposed to say?" Tiz asked.

"Nothing," I said again. "If somebody asks, you tell them Danni's fine. If they press you, you can tell them to talk to me and I'll settle them down. But I swear I'll kick the shit out of anyone who shoots back. Danni will have her say in the cage, and that's all there is to it. Got it?"

Aly and Tiz nodded grudgingly. That was fine by me. I expected them to do what I asked, but I had no illusions they'd be happy about it.

"Just let it go, guys," I said. "We all know it's bullshit. That's all that matters."

They nodded again, then grumbled their way out the door while the notably silent Emma hung back.

"You alright?" she asked after the others had gone.

"Close the door."

She smiled like this was going to be fun.

"Aaaaaaannnd, go!" she said as the latch clicked into place.

"Is that bitch crazy?" I said, gesturing toward the screen where Cole's smug face had appeared a few moments ago. "Does she understand who she's talking about? Is her mind so shot that the last fight is all she can remember? Did Danni beat her so stupid that she has no memory of what happened the time before?"

"She got her big win," Emma said. "She's living it up while she can."

"Bullshit," I said. "She thinks this is reality finally settling in. That Danni winning the first fight was like some sort of mistake, or something."

"Has Danni seen this?"

"How would I know?" I snapped. "Even if she had, Ms. Always Take The High Road wouldn't say anything about it. Hell, if I went in there right now and showed it to her, she'd just shrug and that would be the end of it."

"What do you want her to do?"

"Throw something!" I said. "Scream! Yell! Have a fit, just like I am now! I mean, I get why she doesn't say anything to the press, but behind closed doors? I'd put my fist right through the TV."

"Would you?"

I stopped and looked at her.

"If it was you, would you really have let your emotions go like that?"

The answer, of course, was no. If I were in Danni's place... knowing I was going to get a chance to get back in that cage and shut my opponent up with my fists... I'd simply let the comments fuel me. To remind me why it was that I came here every day and worked myself until I could barely stand the pain.

"I'll tell you one thing," I said. "If I ever get my hands on Cheryl Cole..."

"OK," Emma interrupted. "I think it best you not say anything I'll have to testify about later, you know?"

Leave it to Emma to put a smile on my face.

"You have a point," I admitted.

With that settled, this seemed like a good moment to bring up what happened after the Team event.

"Hey listen," I said, "this tournament coming up... you know I was just fooling around, right? I absolutely believe you can win it."

"I know," she said. "I think Tiff already told you what that was all about."

"She did, but I just wanted to make sure you knew where I stood."

"I appreciate it."

"How's the training going, anyway?"

"Would it be wrong to say it's been more fun than I imagined?"

"No reason work can't be fun," I shrugged, "and I can tell Danni is enjoying herself, too."

"You think she knows what we're up to?"

"Yep," I said, "but you guys are doing a good job of making it something she can swallow."

"That's the idea, and like I said... it's fun."

"Just remember not to have too much fun."

"No, we're good. We all have the same goals, and we're all focused. It's just... I don't know why, but it's fun to do it together."

Again, that sounded a bit like the group was losing sight of the goal. But I'd been checking in with Steph, and she was not only satisfied but pleasantly surprised. No, scratch that. Things were going so well that she was mildly pissed at herself for not doing more of this cross-training in the past.

"Sounds good to me," I said. "Just let me know if you think anything's missing."

She nodded, then paused as she got up to leave.

"One thing about those comments you made," she said. "They were public."

"Emma, we kid like that all the time. I think people expect it, but if I offended you..."

"That's not what I'm saying. I mean they were public. Everyone knows what you said. So, if I win..."

The devilish grin appeared, and I realized what she was getting at. If she did win, I'd have some crow to eat.

"You bring the belt, and I'll bring the salt," I said.

"You got yourself a deal," she said firmly.

Then she left, and I immediately went back to the computer, brought up my cache of video from her recent fights and resumed my studies. If she won the tournament, I would happily eat my words. But then I was going to drag her back into the cage and remind her who the teacher was around here.

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Days, then weeks, then months went by. The rookies learned the way things changed when they came through the doors of *Rampage Sports*. The process was not without its hurdles though, as I quickly realized the initiation Emma spoke of was an ongoing thing. My first clue came when I noticed J-Law heading through the gym empty-handed, with Dove right behind her carrying not one, but two gym bags. Later it was Daya working as porter for Emily - and jawing all the way, I might add. I didn't have to ask any questions to figure out what was going on. The word *hazing* is taboo nowadays because - like everything else - people take it too far too often. But I had no problem with what I was seeing here because, in truth, this was how it had to be. Simply accepting the younger fighters would have made them into something akin to club mascots or class pets. The senior fighters knew this, so they were putting the screws to them a little bit. Nothing dangerous or crazy. Just letting the new kids earn it. And, to their credit, the rookies were taking it without complaint. In return, they would not only become part of the group, but also gain a gym full of experience they could tap into. It was not an unfair trade.

It was also timely because the young trio were in desperate need of help.

A new brainstorm had recently come out of the league office. For obvious reasons, rookies rarely ever had the ranking points needed to make the big tournaments. For other obvious reasons, the league wanted more exposure for their newest talents. The solution? Feature the rookies in a separate event the night before each tourney. Each would take part in a single fight, giving her a chance to showcase her wares on the bigger stage. It was not a bad idea... until the advertising department got involved.

Apparently they couldn't find a way to sell it as a simple competition, so they turned it into something that sounded like a reality show. The matchups would be generated by random draw and announced on the night of the competition. There would be no prep work or in-depth strategy to lean on. Just you and your raw skills against whoever they threw you in there with. Win, and glory was yours. Lose, and they'd toss your beaten body into a pit of hungry alligators.

I might have made that last part up.

They called their new creation *Rookie Gut Check*, which I found apt because - like so many of their bright ideas - it made me want to throw up.

Despite the bloody savagery it's made to look like, MMA is an athletic competition like any other. You prepare for your opponent. Study her tactics and plan with your team. Sharpen the skills you'll need to beat her, and think long and hard about the weaknesses she'll try to exploit to defeat you. Yes, in the end, it's just you and her. But the idea is that you should both be in top form. Completely prepared for the battle. Then you lock the cage and see what's what.

This rookie thing was nothing like that. It was more like legitimized street fighting. A glorified pit fight between women who were trained to beat each others brains in.

Trust me. I'm an expert on such things.

The biggest problem was the official league definition of a *rookie* as being any fighter with less than ten fights. Liv had three fights under her belt. Dove and Daya had two apiece. The blonde pair had each squeaked out a single, shaky victory. Daya was winless. None of them were ready for the worst-case scenario - drawing an opponent with nine fights worth of experience. Especially not without a chance to prepare.

So, I hated it, but, like so many things, there was little I could do but sigh and make sure the three had every ounce of help they needed. And having their teammates behind them certainly went a long way on that front.

Meanwhile, the cross-training among the veterans continued, with the unexpected matchups spreading beyond just Danni. Tiz throwing hands with Emma. Cat mixing it up with Torrie Wilson. I swear to you, I even found Steph in the cage with J-Law one day. The more it happened, the more the whole thing started to take on a shape I could recognize. It was much more than just playtime. The women thirsted for new challenges and new techniques, and this system had shown them they could find those things right here.

I agreed with Steph. We should have done this a long time ago.

As for Danni... well, I refused to let her off the hook regarding her ambidextrous fighting skills. The more I saw her do it, the more I realized she was already pretty good at it. So, I pushed both of us. I studied and practiced and learned to get better at handling it, then I challenged her to get even better. But, despite the fact that she kept finding ways to beat me, she refused to acknowledge that the skill was reaching the point where she'd be able to use it. Eventually, she tried to draw a hard line.

"We're only a couple of months out from the tournament," she said. "It's time for us to forget this and get focused."

"But you're getting so good at it," I protested.

"I don't even feel comfortable with it," she said. "I'm forcing it."

"Yeah, you're forcing your fists into my face."

"I'm serious," she said. "It still feels like a gimmick."

Given what I knew of her, it came as no surprise she was being stubborn, which left me with a problem. If she was going to be this difficult, then I would only be able to push her so far. But I had a plan.

I let the subject drop for a few days to let her think I was done with it. Then I flipped the script on her.

"I want you to try that stance switch on me again," I said as our evening workout was drawing to a close.

Her eyes narrowed and her expression hardened, but I hurried into my explanation before she could say anything.

"It's got nothing to do with you," I said, putting a little whine in my voice. "It's me. I'm losing my mind."

The narrowed eyes stayed but her features softened just a bit. Call it a look of suspicious concern.

"This is going to sound stupid, but I have to figure out how you do it. And I have to learn to defend it."

"Why?" she asked skeptically.

"Because it's driving me crazy that you have this technique you can pull out and just knock me on my ass whenever you want."

I was selling it hard and doing a pretty good job of it. It was easy because it really WAS driving me crazy. I mean, how the fuck was she doing that? And why couldn't I come up with a solid way to counter it?

"I told you," she said, "it was supposed to be a one time thing. I wasn't planning on ever doing it again, and, honestly, we've wasted enough time on it. If I knew you'd react like this I never would have done it."

"That does me no good, now," I said. "Every time we do this, I'm waiting for you to spring it on me."

"I just said I wasn't..."

"Yeah... I know, I know. But it's more than that. I can't stand the thought that you CAN. That's the thing."

A wry, knowing smile creased her lips.

"Sounds like I've wounded your competitive pride."

"Wipe that smile off your face and get over her and help me," I shot back.

The smile stayed, but we resumed the spar. And, sure enough, after a few exchanges, I saw her make the switch.

Why did she do it? Because she felt bad for me?

Hell no.

She might love me, but you have to remember we're fighters. That makes us a different kind of animal. One that thrives on competition and rivalry. When we weren't sharing a meal or enjoying a quiet evening together, we were looking to kick each other's ass. So, making her think her new skill was torturing me didn't garner any sympathy. It made her want to do it more often.

Before long, watching for the switch became second nature for me. It was hard. There are so many things to think about in a fight, it was easy to lose track. Especially late, when you're feeling the pain and exhaustion the most. But she was getting so good at it that I knew I had to keep my eye out if I wanted to survive.

Meanwhile, my plan was working. By treating it like some sort of special torture she saved just for me, I don't think Danni noticed how fluidly she was making the switch. In one smooth, subtle step, she could flip her entire stance. The wrong foot would come forward, then the hands would come up in the opposite positions and it would all look perfectly normal if you weren't paying close, rigid attention.

The fact that my strategy was effective didn't make her gullible. It simply made clear exactly how well I knew her.

It also clarified for me how much I loved her and why. I knew I loved her spirit and her strength and her selflessness, but that moment in the cage with her solidified the one thing I constantly marveled at but never stopped and thought about. That, deep down, she and I were the same. I had used that to manipulate her a little, and it had worked. More importantly, I knew she could do the same thing to me.

I've worked long and hard to become my own person. Now, here was this woman who could probably control me like a puppet on a string. It should have terrified me, but it didn't. I wanted her to have those strings.

With the tournament coming up fast, I decided this was not the time to rock the boat. I chose not to point out how good she'd gotten at converting her stance, nor did I share what I was feeling about us. Unlike the last time, both the training and the relationship were running smooth. She would go out and use this tournament to show the world what she was made of, and afterward, we would sit down and I would tell her what was going on in my head.

Then the two of us would work to perfect this fantastic new skill of hers, and, when she finally got her shot at Cole and that divisional title, poor Cheryl wouldn't know what hit her.